> international waters and not to retreat from them by even one step.[7]

Ambassador Dobrynin, while unaware of how Moscow intended to react, told Robert Kennedy when they met on Tuesday evening, that if Soviet ships were stopped by force, it would be ‘an act of war’.[8]

Military plans for an attack on Cuba were well-developed before the missile crisis. With the continuing Soviet military build-up during 1962, on 2 October Defense Secretary McNamara instructed the Joint Chiefs of Staff to review and revise their military plans. They were to consider six scenarios: a Soviet move against Berlin; evidence of Soviet offensive weapons in Cuba; a Cuban attack on Guantánamo Bay or elsewhere; a popular uprising in Cuba; Cuban armed aid to subvert other parts of the Western Hemisphere; and a decision by the President that the situation was no longer consistent with US national security.[9]

Contingency planning thus preceded discovery of the missiles and included three principal plans for military action: Oplan 312 comprised air attacks; Oplan 314 entailed a large-scale invasion, following eighteen days of aerial bombardment; Oplan 316 was a faster-paced invasion with five days bombardment preceding an amphibious assault three days later. Yet, despite the work of US military planners, some key aspects of the blockade were developed only after the missiles were discovered and indeed after the blockade was announced.

Previously planned military exercises for October 1962 also expedited preparations. Naval and amphibious landing exercises were scheduled for October, including PHILBRIGLEX 62, designed to rehearse an amphibious assault to overthrow a fictional dictator. The exercise was to take place off Vieques in Puerto Rico and the name of the dictator was Ortsac (Castro spelt backwards).

A naval blockade was an integral part of the military planning. General Maxwell Taylor explained to the President on 16 October that, after the air attacks, a blockade was necessary to prevent more offensive arms coming in.[10] The suggestion that a naval blockade was an alternative to attack on Cuba was certainly never countenanced by the Joint Chiefs. When informed